

CHAPTER I

THE OLD REGIME

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THE childhood of a French nobleman in the eighteenth century was not usually the period of his life upon which he looked back with either affection or regret. The doctrine that parents exist for the sake of their children was not then accepted, and the loving care and hourly attention bestowed upon the children of to-day would have appeared ridiculous to sensible people. When Rousseau, the first man of sentiment, abandoned all his children, one after the other, to be brought up as unknown foundlings, his conduct was thought odd but not vile. The heir to the richest dukedom in France describes how his education was entrusted to one of his father's lackeys who happened to be able to read, how he was dressed in the prettiest clothes for going out but how at home he was left naked and hungry, and how this was the fate of all the children of his age and class.

Family feeling, however, which has always existed more strongly in France than in England, was certainly as prevalent and as powerful at that period as it is to-day. It was a sentiment that cared more for the interests of the family as a whole than for the interests of the separate members of the family. The individual was expected, and often compelled, to make sacrifices in order that the family might benefit.

Charles Maurice de Talleyrand-Périgord was born in Paris on the second of February, 1754. His family was one of the most ancient and illustrious in the kingdom, tracing their descent back to the tenth century and claiming kinship with the sovereign Counts of Périgord. In later years he was fond of saying that the Talleyrands were princes before the Capets were kings, a boast which, if not strictly accurate, was sufficiently plausible to pass muster.